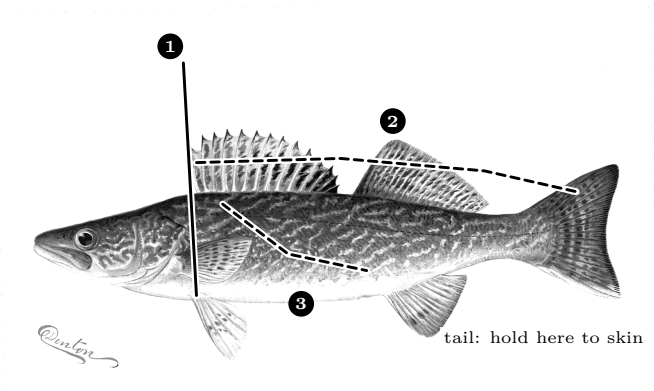




The Pike Perch or Wall-Eyed Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The reason people drive to Wisconsin. Firm, white, large-flaked, and so mild that the fish tastes of what you cook it in.
Texture	Dense and moist, holds together in a pan where a bluegill falls apart. Forgiving of slight overcooking.
Oil	Low. Keeps poorly frozen past about four months — the flavour goes flat rather than fishy.
Best size	18–22 in, which is also the legal window here. A very large walleye is coarser and worth releasing anyway.
Yield	About 35% of whole weight as skinless fillet. A 20 in fish gives two fillets around 6 oz each — one generous portion.
Skin	Always remove it. Walleye skin is tough and does not crisp.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate**, angling slightly toward the head, until you feel the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone from head to tail, letting the spine guide the knife. One long stroke beats twenty short ones. Leave the fillet attached at the tail as a handle.
3. **Lift the fillet and slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little meat as you can. Or skip this and pull the rib bones with pliers after skinning.
4. **Skin it:** lay the fillet skin-side down, hold the tail, and run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle, sawing gently while pulling the skin.
5. **Take the cheeks.** Two coin-sized nuggets of the best meat on the fish, in the hollow behind and below the eye. Cut a semicircle through the skin, pop the meat out with the knife tip, peel the skin off. Most people throw these away. Do not be most people.
6. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it on ice or in the pan.

Bones

Rib cage	The only bones to deal with, and step 3 removes them.
No Y-bones	Unlike pike, a walleye fillet is genuinely boneless once the ribs are out. <i>see the Cooking Northern Pike sheet</i>
Run a finger	Along the fillet before cooking, tip to tail, feeling for anything sharp. Thirty seconds now saves a bad mouthful later.

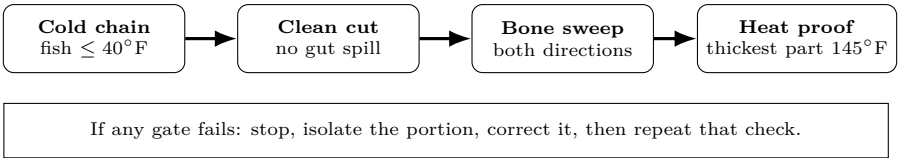
Three ways to cook it

Method	How
Pan-fried	The standard, and the best. Dry the fillet hard. Dredge in seasoned flour, or beaten egg then cracker crumbs. Medium-high heat, butter and a little oil so the butter does not burn. Three minutes a side for a half-inch fillet. Lemon. Nothing else.
Beer-battered	For a fish fry. Flour, cornstarch, baking powder, cold beer, whisked to thin-cream consistency. 375 °F oil, three to four minutes to golden. Drain on a rack, never on paper — paper steams the crust off.
Baked whole fillets	For a bigger batch. 400 °F, butter, lemon slices, paprika, ten to twelve minutes. Done when it flakes at a gentle push and the flesh has just turned opaque.

The one rule

Walleye is a mild fish and every minute past done makes it worse. Pull it when the centre has *just* gone from glassy to opaque — it carries on cooking off the heat. Overcooked walleye is dry and ordinary, which is a waste of the best fish in the lake.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For walleye, pike, bass and catfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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